

Chapter 114-2

Father Liang had been extremely busy at the company lately, running himself ragged. He had delegated his work to others a long time ago. Getting on in years, he found it increasingly difficult to handle things, but with his two sons absent, he had no choice but to grit his teeth and carry on.

After coming home, forget about having a pleasant expression—he couldn't even manage a smile.

Eventually, he became so busy he didn't even have time to come home.

Meeting after meeting, documents that could never be finished.

Father Liang was exhausted both physically and mentally. He had thought he would enjoy his twilight years surrounded by children and grandchildren, but instead, this mess had happened.

Last night, Father Liang heard about Liang Wanwan and Liang Xinran's argument, and that Liang Wanwan had actually slapped Liang Xinran. After a long silence, he hesitantly discussed with Qiu Zimin, "How about we just give Xinran a sum of money and send her away?"

Upon hearing this, Qiu Zimin immediately burst into tears. Her already frail body caused her to cough up blood on the spot. Then she leaned against the headboard and said to Father Liang, "Liang Zu, oh Liang Zu, it was you who lost our daughter back then. How can you say such things? We searched for our daughter for twenty-five years. Now that we've found her, you want to abandon her. Are you even human?!"

Father Liang felt melancholic after hearing this. "What else can I do? Xinzhou and Xinhe have formed a united front now. They won't come to the company, and I can't reach them. What am I supposed to do?! Even someone with as good a temper as Wanwan hit her—are you saying there's no problem with her? Perhaps Xinzhou was right from the start: they're from different social circles, there's no need to force integration. Just give her a sum of money and be done with it. It would show our good intentions."

"No!" Qiu Zimin flatly refused. "They were all born from me. It's one thing for Liang Xinzhou to favor that outsider, but Xinhe and Wanwan have been bewitched by someone too—it must be that wretched girl!"

Qiu Zimin spoke with both anger and hatred, tears streaming down her face. "If you want to send Xinran away, then send me away too. Why must you look for reasons from the victim? It was our responsibility that Xinran was lost back then. If you had watched her properly, would she have been stolen by human traffickers? If you hadn't made so many enemies in business back then, wouldn't our Xinran have grown up peacefully and happily by our side?!"

"She's suffered so much for all these years and been hurt so badly. How can you bear to give her a second blow?! Liang Zu, this is the sin you committed back then. You owe me this!" Qiu Zimin condemned Father Liang righteously. After she finished speaking, her anger attacked her heart and she began coughing violently. She cried and made a scene at Father Liang all night, forcing him into submission. "Alright, alright, alright, I won't bring it up again."

After saying this, he was also puzzled. "I don't know what's wrong with these children. They used to be so well-behaved, never causing conflicts with the family, especially Xinzhou. But now... Sigh, it's all because we didn't pay attention to Liang Shi back then and always left her for Xinzhou to take care of."

"Liang Shi is nothing but a curse! Back then, Daoist Master Yunyin¹ said that keeping her would lead to disaster. Let's sever ties with her," Qiu Zimin said. "Have you forgotten? Daoist Master Yunyin said that after transferring her fortune, she would be useless. Moreover, her fortune would affect Dongheng. We must sever ties with her!"

"How are we supposed to sever ties?" Liang Zu frowned. "Just transfer her household registration² out? That's too absurd. Besides, she's married now and already has her own independent household registration."

In elite circles, acknowledging family was easier than rejecting family.

To acknowledge family, you just throw a banquet, bring your biological daughter to meet friends in the circle, and make your stance clear.

But to reject family?

It was basically handled with cold treatment.

Everyone generally assumed that when a family's biological daughter returned, the previous one belonged to someone else's family. If that person had biological parents, they would definitely be sent away. If they weren't sent away, they would face discrimination and contempt in the circle. No one would care about such matters.

But Liang Shi no longer moved in their circles.

She didn't attend banquets and didn't hang around with her former fair-weather friends.

Losing the Liang family's protection hadn't affected her at all.

The more Qiu Zimin thought about it, the angrier she became. She was so furious last night that she couldn't sleep all night.

When she woke up early in the morning, she felt a knot in her chest that ached terribly. Father Liang had already left early for the company, so she had the servants call the family doctor to come and set up an IV drip.

Liang Xinran woke up in the morning and stayed by her side, bringing her water and medicine, helping her to the bathroom—extremely attentive.

Only at times like these did Qiu Zimin feel she had done the right thing.

A biological daughter was definitely better.

After all, she was flesh that had fallen from her own body.

But having been slapped by Liang Wanwan, the red mark on her face still hadn't faded overnight, which was heartbreaking enough.

Actually, when Qiu Zimin first heard about the incident, her first reaction was to scold Liang Xinran. "Everything was fine. Why did you touch her clothes?"

But she had only said this one sentence when Liang Xinran stood there with tears welling up in her eyes.

Liang Xinran had an exceptionally innocent-looking face. Anyone who saw her wouldn't have the heart to condemn her further.

Moreover, she said, "I... I just saw that my younger sister's clothes were dirty and thought I'd help wash them. And didn't we buy a pretty piece of clothing when we went... went shopping last time? I just wanted her to wear that one... I didn't expect... that there would be... her things inside."

Liang Xinran spoke haltingly, crying so hard she could barely breathe, yet still forcing herself not to let the tears fall.

When the tears did fall, she raised her hand to wipe them away.

Qiu Zimin suddenly didn't know what to say to her. All that remained was heartache.

To comfort her, Qiu Zimin even helped by scolding Liang Wanwan. "It was just a sketchbook. Did she have to make such a big fuss? Next time she comes back, Mom will discipline her for you."

After coaxing her for a long time, Liang Xinran finally stopped crying, but her eyes were still red. Whenever she spoke, her voice was choked and hoarse.

During the day, with Liang Xinran's company, Qiu Zimin's mood finally improved a little. But unexpectedly, as evening approached, just after she finished her afternoon IV drip, Liang Xinran suggested she put on a thick coat so the two of them could take a walk in the back garden. She had just put on her coat and hadn't even walked out the door when her two sons came charging in aggressively, looking like they were here to settle accounts.

Upon seeing her two sons, Qiu Zimin's mood took a sharp downturn. The good mood she had finally managed to adjust was gone again.

She put on a cold face and said sarcastically, "So the two young masters are finally willing to come back."

Liang Xinzhou didn't look at her but looked directly at Liang Xinran. "We came back to discuss something with you."

His tone was businesslike, without a hint of respect.

Qiu Zimin immediately became irritated. "Liang Xinzhou, why are you looking at her? You only know how to bully the weak and fear the strong? If you have something to say, say it to me."

"Fine." Liang Xinzhou agreed readily, then looked at her. "Then I'll say it to you."

Qiu Zimin: "..."

She hadn't expected Liang Xinzhou to agree so readily, or rather, she hadn't expected Liang Xinzhou to actually be here to settle accounts.

What accounts?

Apart from Liang Wanwan and Ling Dang, Qiu Zimin couldn't think of anything else.

She frowned and sat back on the sofa, forcing herself to maintain her composure for a while. Before long, she was tired. Her body felt like a machine running at full speed—she was now exhausted both physically and mentally.

For so many years, she had always felt she had raised her children extremely well—obedient, filial, and the brothers got along harmoniously.

She had fantasized countless times: Liang Xinzhou treated even someone else's daughter so well.

If it were his own biological sister, wouldn't Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe spoil her to the heavens?

But she never expected reality to be completely different from what she had imagined.

Footnotes:

¹ Daoist Master Yunyin (雲隱道長): A Daoist priest/master that Qiu Zimin consulted. In Chinese culture, Daoist masters are sometimes consulted for fortune-telling, feng shui, and spiritual matters. The name "Yunyin" means "hidden in clouds."

² Household registration (戶口, hùkǒu): China's household registration system that records family members. Traditionally, being removed from a family's household registration is a significant act that symbolizes severing family ties. When someone gets married, they typically establish their own independent household registration.